

Written Communications Guide

GOODWILL INDUSTRIES OF NORTHWEST NORTH CAROLINA, INC.

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Introduction

This **Written Communications Guide** is a set of rules and guidelines to equip employees of Goodwill Industries of Northwest North Carolina, Inc. (Goodwill) with the knowledge and tools to ensure that internal and external communications are consistent, credible, and professional.

As a nonprofit that serves the local community, Goodwill is committed to communicating clearly, concisely, accurately, and professionally. In doing so, we will enhance our brand image and continue to establish ourselves as an exemplary organization, worthy of the community's trust.

Quick Reference: Goodwill Terms

Official Company Name

Our official company name is **Goodwill Industries of Northwest North Carolina, Inc.** In formal communications, such as press releases, letters printed on company letterhead, articles, and legal documents, our full, official name should be used in the first instance followed by the shortened name in parentheses. This allows the use of "Goodwill" in all following instances. *(See example in first paragraph in this Guide's [Introduction](#).)*

Other acceptable forms of our company name are:

- Goodwill Industries of Northwest NC
- Goodwill Industries of Northwest North Carolina
- Goodwill
- Goodwill Industries
- Goodwill Northwest NC

Do not use the following terms for our company name: GoodwillNWNC, Goodwill NWNC, Goodwill Industries NWNC. These terms are not acceptable in any type of communication except as a hashtag or social media handle (e.g., #GoodwillNWNC).

Goodwill Locations

Career Centers

The term "Career Center" is the umbrella term that encompasses all sites offering workforce development services. There are several different types of Career Centers: Workforce Development Centers, Career Connections Centers, and partner sites/other locations.

Workforce Development Centers

Goodwill's Workforce Development Centers are named according to the county in which they are located. We currently have five (5) Workforce Development Centers, listed below:

- Buncombe County Workforce Development Center (1616 Patton Avenue, Asheville)
- Catawba County Workforce Development Center (413 Thornburg Drive, Conover)
- Davidson County Workforce Development Center (719 West Center Street, Lexington)
- Forsyth County Workforce Development Center (2701 University Parkway, Winston-Salem)
- Iredell County Workforce Development Center (124 Fourth Crescent Place, Statesville)

Career Connections Centers

Goodwill also operates smaller centers called Career Connections Centers which can be abbreviated as Career Centers or Career Connections. These are also named by the county in which they are located. Following are the current Career Centers:

- Burke County Career Connections Center (118 Bost Road, Morganton)
- Catawba County Career Connections Center (837 Conover Boulevard West, Conover)
- Forsyth County Career Connections Center (2 locations)
 - 2701 University Parkway, Winston-Salem
 - 2760 Peters Creek Parkway, Winston-Salem
- Haywood County Career Connections Center (160 South Main Street, Waynesville)
- Henderson County Career Connections Center (155 Four Seasons Mall, Hendersonville)
- Rowan County Career Connections Center (1923 South Main Street, Salisbury)
- Surry County Career Connections Center (1457 North Bridge Street, Elkin)
- Wilkes County Career Connections Center (1821 U.S. Highway 421, Wilkesboro)

Other Workforce Development Site Locations

The Prosperity Center, a United Way collaborative with Financial Pathways of the Piedmont (Winston-Salem) should be referred to as The Prosperity Center, always preceded by “The”.

Goodwill operates or has staff on site at numerous partner agency locations and the names are often dictated by the partner agency or the program. For a full list of Goodwill Career Centers, along with contact information and hours of operation, please refer to our website at www.goodwillnwc.org.

Donated Goods Retail Locations

Retail Stores

Goodwill’s mission is primarily funded through the sale of donated items in our 47 retail stores and 3 outlet stores. While store numbers (e.g., Store 11) and community references (e.g., Viewmont) are often used for internal communications, external communications should refer to Goodwill stores as “Goodwill Store”, “Goodwill Outlet Store”, or “Goodwill Retail Store”. When needed for context, the city name should be used. In cities where we operate more than one store, the street should also be included. Examples of acceptable terms for retail stores are below. For a complete list of retail and outlet stores with contact information and hours of operation, visit our website at www.goodwillnwc.org.

- Goodwill Retail Store, Mooresville (Williamson Road)
- Goodwill Retail Store (University Parkway, Winston-Salem)
- Goodwill Store, Asheville (Tunnel Road)
- Goodwill Store (Lenoir-Rhyne Blvd, Hickory)

Donation Centers

Goodwill operates dozens of donation centers across our territory where our attendants collect donations from the community in support of our mission. All our donation centers are staffed, which sets us apart from other for-profit and nonprofits that operate unmanned drop boxes. To underscore

this, we refer to our donation centers as Attended Donation Centers, abbreviated as ADCs. While community references are acceptable in internal communications, for external communications the following naming convention is used: City - Street. As an example, the ADC at 811 S. Main Street in Kernersville is standardized as “Kernersville – Main St”. For a list of ADCs, visit our website at www.goodwillnwc.org.

Workforce Development Programs and Partnerships

The Professional Center by Goodwill is a program that occupies space within Goodwill’s headquarters in Winston-Salem. It should include “by Goodwill” in the first instance but in following instances can be abbreviated as “The Professional Center”.

Many Goodwill programs are offered in partnership with other nonprofit and government agencies. In formal communications, the full program or service name should be stated in the first instance and must include mention of partner agencies. In following instances, the program name can be abbreviated, and partners do not have to be mentioned again unless needed for context. A few examples are listed below. For a full list of Goodwill programs and services, please visit www.careersbygoodwill.org.

First Instance	Following Instances
Access Center Adult High School, offered in partnership with Asheville-Buncombe Technical Community College	Access Center
Project Re-entry Program, offered in partnership with Piedmont Triad Regional Council	Project Re-entry ¹
The Prosperity Center, a United Way collaborative in partnership with Financial Pathways of the Piedmont	The Prosperity Center
Goodwill partners with the Piedmont Triad Regional Workforce Development Board and Goodwill Industries of Central NC in the operation of NCWorks Career Centers and NCWorks Career Services locations in seven counties in central and western North Carolina.	NCWorks

When referring to Goodwill’s partner agencies, employers, and other organizations, always verify names, spelling, and professional titles. Obtain approval to use any brands or logos prior to use and obtain files from authorized representatives – never cut and paste logos or landmarks from websites.

Workforce Development Terminology

Persons enrolled in Goodwill’s workforce development programs or benefitting from Goodwill’s workforce development services are termed “program participants”. (Note – Professional Center by Goodwill program participants can also be referred to as “clients”).

¹ Note the difference between the branded “Project Re-entry” which is the official name of the program and “reentry”, which is the general term used to describe efforts to reduce barriers to employment for justice-involved individuals. Other programs have similar distinctions between brand and generic terms.

Email Signatures

For those employees using Outlook as their e-mail application, it is important to use a standard signature. An e-mail signature consists of text that is automatically added to the end of outgoing e-mail messages. Below is the signature which has been approved by the executive staff for use by all Goodwill employees.

Information to include:

First M. Last
Job Title
Company Name
Office: 555-555-5555 x15555
Email Address
Company Website URL

Example:

John A. Doe
Communications Manager
Goodwill Industries of Northwest NC
Office: 336-724-3621 x11394
jdoe@goodwillnwnnc.org
www.goodwillnwnnc.org

Depending on the preferred mode of communication with external contacts, an employee may choose to include a mobile number below the primary telephone number. Optional: include the physical or mailing address below the company name.

Do not “customize” your signature template in any way, including the addition of colors, quotes, icons, images, logos, etc. It is important that email signatures are consistent throughout the organization.

Using Accessible and Inclusive Language

The thousands of individuals to whom Goodwill provides services each year are challenged with diverse barriers to employment and prosperity. The way in which Goodwill’s representatives communicate should not be an additional barrier. Using accessible, inclusive language signals that all are equal and welcome, ensuring ease of access to and use of Goodwill’s services.

Plain Language

Did you know that the average American adult reads on a 9th grade level? Newspapers write on that grade level to make their content accessible to as many people as possible. We must always be aware that many of Goodwill’s program participants have educational or language barriers that affect their reading ability. We should, therefore, be committed to not talking down to anyone or using language, terminology or “jargon” that could marginalize, offend, or confuse participants. Always be aware and considerate of your audience.

- Avoid complex sentence construction that includes many forms of punctuation, conjunctions, etc. Avoid using long sentences; instead try using two or three brief sentences.
- Use common language that most people are likely to understand. Avoid words and terms that require a higher reading level.
- When possible, use bulleted lists.
- Avoid using filler language (e.g., “in order to...”, “18 years of age”) that complicates your message.

Inclusive Language

Respectful language focuses on the person, not on physical appearance or other characteristics. These are general guidelines. If a specific individual asks you to use (or not use) certain words to describe them, please respect their wishes.

- Avoid making references to a person's age, gender, ethnicity or race, religion, abilities or sexual orientation unless it is relevant to the program or service in which they are participating.
- Use gender-neutral terms. If referring to a general, non-specific individual, write either "he or she..." or "they." Yes, it's grammatically correct to use "they" even if you are referring to only one person. Example: "If someone needs a new resume, Career Connections can assist them."
- Disability: As with age, gender or other characteristics, do not refer to a person's disability unless it is relevant. Avoid using negative language (e.g., "victim" or "suffers from..."). Always emphasize the person first. Their condition is only one part of who that person is. Example: Use "person with a disability" (not "disabled person").
- HIPPA and Privacy: Many of our program participants have experienced homelessness, addiction, incarceration, or other challenging circumstances. As with disabilities, focus on the person first, rather than the person's status. Example: Use "job seeker who has been justice-involved".
 - o Be knowledgeable about and aware of the conditions that are protected by HIPPA and Goodwill's policies and practices.
 - o Program participants must consent to sharing any/all personal information, internally or externally.

General Writing and Grammar Guidelines

- Always use the simplest possible word (for example, "use" instead of "utilize").
- Use professional, easy-to-understand words and sentence construction.
- Avoid clichés such as "dress to impress" (just write "dress professionally" or "dress neatly").
- Consider whether your audience will understand jargon, acronyms, or special terms. When in doubt, spell it out.

Resources

There are many free resources available online to help fine tune your written communications, including:

- [Purdue OWL](#): The Online Writing Lab (OWL) at Purdue University houses writing resources and instructional material, and we provide these as a free service of the Writing Lab at Purdue. Students, members of the community, and users worldwide will find information to assist with many writing projects.
- [Grammarly](#): Grammarly is a cloud-based writing assistant that reviews spelling, grammar, punctuation, clarity, engagement, and delivery mistakes. It uses AI (artificial intelligence) to identify and search for an appropriate replacement for each mistake it locates. It also allows users to customize their style, tone, and context-specific language.

Common Style Guidelines

Abbreviations and Acronyms

Every industry and sector use abbreviations and acronyms (industry-specific language). Nonprofit organizations are no different. It is important to remember that people who do not work in our field may not understand the meaning of the "language" we use in our internal interactions every day. People within Goodwill who work in different areas or programs may even be unfamiliar with the terms we use.

- Context is everything. Ask yourself if the person reading your communication is likely to know what the acronym or abbreviation means.
- The first time you use the term, write out its complete name. You can use the acronym or abbreviation thereafter. Example: Goodwill's Donated Goods Retail (DGR).
- When writing acronyms, use capital letters with no periods. Example: WFD, NC, NCDVR, etc.

Addresses

When addressing an envelope to mail via the U.S. Postal Service (USPS), always use [standard U.S. Postal Service abbreviations](#), for both the street address and state, whether used in text or the block address form. Use the same guidelines when listing an address on any informational marketing materials. Examples:

Goodwill Retail Store
2701 University Pkwy.
Winston-Salem, NC 27105

Goodwill Workforce Development Center
1616 Patton Ave.
Asheville, NC 28806

NOTE: No comma is used between the state abbreviation and ZIP Code.

Verify that you are spelling street names correctly. Include all additional directional information such as NE, SW, etc. Omitting this information can direct people to the wrong location. A list of US Postal Service state codes is available at this site: [State Abbreviations & Postal Codes Cheatsheet \(infoplease.com\)](#).

See also: [States and Cities \(Place Names\)](#)

Ages

When referring to a person, use numerals for all ages. For any other application, the general rule about numbers applies. Write out numbers from one to nine and use numerals for 10 and up. Examples: "I am 39 years old." or "In its second year, the store increased sales."

If you are using a person's or object's age as a description, use hyphens as you would with other types of adjectives. Examples: "A 39-year-old person..." or "A two-year-old store..."

See also: [Numbers](#)

Dates (Months, Years, Days)

Use this format: Day, Month, Year. Example: Friday, March 20, 2021

- However, it will not always be necessary to include the year. For instance, if a job fair or meeting takes place next month, the year will be obvious.

Do not use "st, rd, or th" with dates. Example: March 3, not March 3rd. Exception: if you're referring to a date more generally, it's acceptable to use this format (For example, "I'll see you on the 27th.")

Do not abbreviate days of the week. Spell them out: Monday, Tuesday; not Mon., Tues. Exception: when space is limited in marketing materials such as flyers, brochures, social media posts, etc.

Months: When writing a date, do not abbreviate months whose names have five letters or less (March, April, May, June and July). You may abbreviate others as follows: Jan., Feb., Aug., Sept., Oct., Nov., Dec.

- What if you only need to reference a month and year, not a specific day? In that case, don't use abbreviations for any month. Example: "We plan to open in October 2021."
- Note that you do not use a comma in this format: October 2021 or October of 2021, not October, 2021

Job Titles

At Goodwill, the most common use of a formal title is a person's job title. The formal title is the official name of the position (for example, what the person would have on their business card). People also use informal job titles that describe the position, but are not the official job title (e.g., program manager, director). Generally, capitalize formal titles **only** when they appear before a person's name. Do not capitalize the title if it appears after the person's name or if it is informal. Examples:

- Mayor Allen Joines or President and CEO Barbara Maida-Stolle
- Allen Joines is the mayor of Winston-Salem; Barbara Maida-Stolle, president and CEO of Goodwill...

Note: if the person's job title is more than a few words long, it may be easier to read if it is placed after the person's name.

Frequently we use a person's occupation to describe them. Generally, do not capitalize occupations or occupational categories. Examples:

- He is an Army veteran. We encourage veterans to attend the job fair.
- She was hired as a truck driver. He worked as a plumber for several years.

Measurements & Distances

Follow the general rule of numbers: Write out numbers one through nine, use digits for 10 and up. Do not abbreviate units of measurement. Examples: 47 miles; 2 feet; 10 inches

Money

Use the dollar symbol (\$) for specific amounts. For even dollar amounts, do not include cents. Examples: \$27; not \$27.00

- Note that this is an exception to the general numbers rule. This is **ONLY** done when using the dollar/symbol format.

For amounts less than one dollar, do not use the dollars or cents symbols. It can be difficult to read and understand in text. Examples: two cents, not \$0.02

Numbers

Spell out numbers one through nine and use digits for 10 and up. There are a few exceptions, which are explained in more detail in other sections. Do not begin a sentence with a number; spell out the number instead. Example: "Twelve years ago, the store broke all previous sales records." Always use digits for:

- Addresses
- Ages of people
- Dates
- Money (only when using symbols)
- Times

Percentages

Spell out the word percent when including percentages in a sentence instead of using the symbol. Example: 10 percent (not 10%).

Phone numbers

Always use the full area code and phone number. Include an extension whenever possible. Do not use parentheses or periods to separate the sections of the phone number. Example: 336-724-3621 ext. 11900.

Punctuation

The major punctuation marks are the period, comma, exclamation point, question mark, semi-colon, and colon. These marks organize sentences and give them structure. This scope of this guide is not intended to provide detailed information on the use of each of the above punctuation marks. When in doubt about how to use a particular punctuation mark, please consult this resource:

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/punctuation/punctuation/index.html

The four primary style guides for written communication are:

1. Associated Press Stylebook (AP) - <https://www.apstylebook.com/>
2. The Chicago Manual of Style (CMOS) - [The Chicago Manual of Style](#)
3. Modern Language Association of America (MLA) - [MLA Style | Modern Language Association](#)
4. Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association (APA) - [APA Style](#)

The Oxford Comma

The Oxford or Serial Comma is the final comma in a list of things. The four primary style guides accept the use of the Oxford comma; however, it may be necessary to review and evaluate select statements/sentences on an individual basis.

Examples using the Oxford Comma:

- We do not accept donations of used mattresses, building materials, or large appliances.
- Services include resume preparation, job interview coaching, and career counseling.

States and Cities (Place Names)

Spell out a state's full name when using it by itself in a sentence. Example: "He was born in Alaska and grew up in Pennsylvania."

Use this format when referring to towns/cities: City name, State (abbreviated); Example: Marion, NC; Roanoke, VA; Atlanta, GA.

- For a local audience, you may not need to include the state.
- Use postal code abbreviations ONLY when writing addresses.

As with all formal and informal nouns, do not capitalize the words state, county, and city, unless you are using them in the location's formal name. Examples: Forsyth County is hiring for more than 100 positions. The county has dozens of current job openings.

Times

It is generally advised that this format be used: 6 a.m. – not 6AM, 6 A.M., or 6am. If a time is on the hour, do not use a colon and minutes. Example: 8 a.m., not 8:00.

- Exception: The 6am format is used for social media and digital or print advertising where there are space/character limits.

To eliminate confusion, it acceptable to use noon and midnight instead of 12 p.m. and 12 a.m. Regardless of which convention you choose, it's important to be consistent with its use throughout the document/communication.

Common Mistakes

Following are some of the most frequently made errors in writing²:

Topic	Explanation	Tips	Examples
i.e. / e.g.	<i>I.e.</i> and <i>e.g.</i> are both Latin abbreviations. <i>E.g.</i> stands for <i>exempli gratia</i> and means "for example." <i>I.e.</i> is the abbreviation for <i>id est</i> and means "in other words."	When in doubt, replace the abbreviation with the words they stand for and read the sentence aloud to check that it still makes sense. Both <i>i.e.</i> and <i>e.g.</i> should be followed by a comma.	- Healthy exercise (e.g., riding a bike or taking a hike) will help you live longer. - Tracy received a gift from her secret admirer (i.e., her husband).
Your / You're	<i>Your</i> is a possessive adjective used to show ownership. <i>You're</i> is the contraction of "you are".	When using "you're" in a sentence, replace it with "you are" and see if it still makes sense. If not, use <i>your</i> .	- Your hair looks great. - You're my best friend.
It's / Its	<i>It's</i> is a contraction and should be used where a sentence would normally read "it is." <i>Its</i> (no apostrophe) is a possessive word, like "his" and "her".	When using "it's" in a sentence, replace it with "it is" and see if it still makes sense.	- It's raining outside. - The sun was so bright, its rays blinded me.
Misplaced Modifiers	<i>Misplaced modifiers</i> are phrases or clauses placed awkwardly in a sentence so that it appears to refer to an unintended word.	To make sure you are describing the right object, use an adjective directly before the word you want to modify (describe).	- Incorrect: I drank a hot mug of coffee. (<i>This implies that the mug is hot, not the coffee.</i>) - Correct: I drank a mug of hot coffee.
Regardless / Irregardless	<i>Irregardless</i> is a nonstandard (and incorrect) synonym for <i>regardless</i> , which means despite the circumstances.	Use <i>regardless</i> rather than the nonstandard term.	- He will go to the beach tomorrow, regardless of the weather forecast.
Affect / Effect	The verb " <i>affect</i> " denotes the act of changing or influencing something while the noun " <i>effect</i> " is something that occurs due to a cause.	An effect is usually the result of something that has been affected.	- Climate change has greatly affected the world's approach towards energy production. - The effect of climate change is evident in the increase of global temperature.
Ensure / Insure	<i>Ensure</i> means to guarantee or make sure of something. <i>Insure</i> refers to the financial service of insurance.	Only use "insure" if you mean to guard against harm or loss (e.g., insurance policy).	- Alice took steps to ensure that no one cheated at the game. - Alice was glad the arcade was insured against theft.

Proofreading

Proofreading is the process of reviewing the final draft of a piece of writing to ensure consistency and accuracy in grammar, spelling, punctuation, and formatting.

² Sources: Grammarly.com, YourDictionary.com, Merriam-Webster.com, Dictionary.com

Following is a list of basic proofreading guidelines:

- Take a break between composing your message and proofreading.
- Read it aloud to determine how it flows and that the message is clear.
- If possible, proofread a hard copy of your document.
- Check for one type of error at a time. Mark each one. Example: Check for typos, then punctuation, then formatting, etc.
- Proofreading your own communication is never as effective as having a second or even third set of eyes proofing the content. When composing content, build in time to allow trusted colleagues to proof your communication. The Marketing Team is a valuable proofreading resource as well.
- When in doubt, refer to this Written Communications Guide or other resources like those listed in the [Resources](#) section of this file.

Use of Logo and Brandmarks

Company policy states that any creative materials that will be seen or used by external audiences, including but not limited to flyers, brochures, presentations, videos, social media posts, email campaigns, ads, posters, signs, branded apparel and other promotional items, etc., must be created by and/or approved by the Marketing Department (see [Policy MD-800-005](#) on SharePoint). However, there are instances when people outside the Marketing Department will need to use our logo and brandmarks³ in materials like agendas, forms and other types of communications.

As with all organizations, we have strict guidelines relating to the use of our logo and brandmarks which include compliance with all Goodwill Industries International bylaws and requirements for membership. Failure to adhere to the GII bylaws can have serious consequences for our organization and we are monitored for compliance.

If you need to use our logos, please refer to the following resources in the [Marketing Section](#) of SharePoint:

- [Brand guidelines](#) for the use of the Goodwill Industries of Northwest NC logo and the Smiling G logo
- [Logo files](#)

If you have questions about logo or brandmark usage, please contact the Marketing Department at marketing@goodwillnwnc.org.

Images and Copyrights

While it's tempting to grab an image from your search online to use in your presentation, keep in mind that all pictures, illustrations, icons, and imagery are automatically copyrighted and belong to the creator. Unless it is specifically stated, you do not have the right to use anything you find online and doing so is considered unlawful and copyright infringement.

The Marketing Department has licensed the use of tens of thousands of high-quality stock photos, icons, illustrations, infographics, songs, and videos so reach out if you have a particular need. If you are creating

³ Brandmarks are the visual elements, images, symbols, and other identifying features of a company's brand that help it stand out from other businesses and garner attention from customers.

something for external audiences, you will need Marketing's review and approval for your materials prior to sharing (see [Policy MD-800-005](#) on SharePoint).

Summary

We hope that these guidelines will benefit any Goodwill employee whose job description includes communicating in the written form.

As it is impossible to anticipate and/or address every question or exception that may arise in this document, please request your manager's guidance when you are unsure about how to effectively communicate your written message.

Thank you for your commitment to representing your program and Goodwill appropriately and professionally.

This guide was created by Goodwill's Marketing and Communications Department. For more information or to suggest additional content for future revisions, please email the Marketing Team at marketing@goodwillnwc.org.